

BEYOND THE SCORE

Case 4 · Tāwhai Family

Māori intergenerational household on ancestral whenua near Kaikohe: a passed driver course, an unscannable address, and a system for which the land is blank space.

THE HOUSEHOLD

Wiremu “Wiri” Tāwhai 18 · Year 13 (Te Kura), fencing contractor, the one the system addressed

“I live here. My family's lived here. But the system says it's not real.”

Wiri is finishing Year 13 through Te Aho o Te Kura Pounamu after leaving mainstream school over bullying and long travel. He helps his uncle with a small māra kai (food garden) and works part-time fencing. The family lives on whenua Māori (ancestral Māori land) — power and water stable, but the property not individually titled, the mailbox marked only ‘Tāwhai Whānau.’ When he applied for an insurance-linked youth incentive after passing a driver safety course, the form rejected his address: no lease, no mortgage, nothing to verify. He quietly gave up. His phone is second-hand and often without data; the internet lives at the marae, the kura, and his cousins' houses.

Moana Tāwhai 43 · kura staff, marae coordinator

“We're not off-grid. We're just off their map.”

Moana grew up on this whenua and returned after years away in retail and early childhood education. Her life is woven into the marae, the whānau, and the land; she is fluent in te reo Māori and English, resourceful, and quietly resilient. She lost her sister to illness and now coparents a niece as well — responsibility that is relational, not paperwork. She pays bills through the bank's website from the kura, avoids apps, never opted into open banking, and when digital systems fail to recognise her address or household she does not escalate. She adapts, quietly. The silence is becoming heavy.

Koro Hēmi Tāwhai 74 · cultural anchor, former land trust officer

“The land remembers us, even when the systems forget.”

Hēmi is the eldest living member of the Tāwhai line on this whenua, carrying stories of occupation, struggle, and resistance. He has watched banks, councils, and Crown entities cycle through the land for decades — sometimes asking, sometimes taking, rarely listening. Information reaches him through Moana, tangi, and hui, not screens; what matters is done kanohi ki te kanohi (face to face). He does not oppose technology. He believes that without tikanga it is hollow, and when his mokopuna's application was rejected he did not say much — but he noticed.

THE SCENE

SIMULATION 4 · “Still Here, Still Invisible”

Late afternoon on ancestral whenua outside Kaikohe. Wiremu has just returned from a long day fencing with his uncle, and quietly tells Moana that his youth driver discount was declined — not for his driving record, but because the insurer could not verify his

address or 'household profile.' Koro Hēmi listens from his armchair by the fire, joining the conversation with short, weighted kōrero (talk).

WIREMU *(takes off his boots, quiet)* They knocked it back.

MOANA The driver deal?

WIREMU Yeah. Said they couldn't verify our address. No proof of stable residence or income stream.

MOANA *(confused)* But we've lived here... forever.

WIREMU They need paperwork. Like a lease or a mortgage. Our whenua doesn't count.

KORO HĒMI *(speaking low)* To them, this land is blank space.

MOANA *(sighs)* So you did the course, passed the test... and still nothing?

WIREMU Pretty much. They said I could try again with more supporting documents.

MOANA *(sits beside him)* What documents? The whenua is in the trust. There's no power bill in your name, no rates notice.

WIREMU And the mailbox doesn't even have a number — just "Tāwhai Whānau." That's not enough for a system that wants to scan everything.

KORO HĒMI *(gruffly)* They want us to prove we belong, on land that buried our tīpuna.

MOANA We've kept this place going without help. Now we're punished because we didn't turn it into something they can stamp?

WIREMU It's like being invisible. The whenua knows I'm here. You know I'm here. But the system? Nah.

MOANA This is the same with the council too. They came last year after the heavy rains — said parts of the back paddock were now "high risk." Talked about zoning changes. Said if we wanted any adaptation support, we'd need to lodge a formal claim.

WIREMU But we didn't qualify, right?

MOANA *(shaking head)* No formal dwelling title, no documented loss. Same old kōrero.

KORO HĒMI *(grimly)* Flood came through here in '93. Knocked the old whare sideways. No one came then either.

MOANA We built back with what we had. Shed wood. Marae leftovers. Never asked the bank for a cent.

WIREMU It's like if you fix it yourself, they say it never broke.

KORO HĒMI That's the way it is. You're Māori twice. Once in body. Twice in paper.

MOANA They think this is empty land. But this whenua carries names, bones, stories.

WIREMU None of that's on a spreadsheet though.

MOANA And if it's not on the screen, it's not real — to them.

KORO HĒMI *(sipping tea)* But it's still ours. Just not theirs.

WIREMU What do I do now?

MOANA *(pause)* We keep records — not for their tick boxes, but for us. Your uncle can write you a letter. The kura can confirm your address. We do it our way, even if it takes longer.

KORO HĒMI *(softly)* They forget things. Systems change. But whenua remembers. So do we.

[Scene ends. Moana opens the kitchen drawer and takes out a lined exercise book — their whānau's own record of names, movements, work done. Wiremu flips to a blank page. This ledger will not be scanned or scored — but it counts where it matters.]

WHAT MOVED

The whenua failed address verification, and a passed driving course counted for nothing against an unscannable mailbox. The household's answer was its own ledger — records kept for themselves, not for the system's boxes. The exclusion was not new; only the automation was.

ABOUT THIS CASE

The people and events in this case are corpus-constrained composites: relational models built from documented Aotearoa New Zealand research, not portraits of any household, whānau, kāiga or community. The arc is an anticipatory scenario — a structured hypothesis built to be tested, not a record of events.

Full case position, design-shift record, and corpus anchors: BTS_Case4_Trace.